society, the Iraq invasion invited strong cross-country protests. While the decision-making processes on this issue is narrated in detail elsewhere, the Iraq war raised concerns among Indian strategists about its potential negative impact on Afghanistan.[20] US focus on Iraq meant that Afghanistan may not receive the financial, political, and security attention that it deserved. In a heated parliamentary debate, communist MP Nilotpal Basu highlighted that despite committing funds towards the reconstruction of Afghanistan in the initial years of war, the US 'had not kept a single penny for the reconstruction of Afghanistan'.[21]

Though US$ 300 million had been allocated to Afghanistan in the first four days of the Iraq invasion, the US economy was running on daily deficit of US$1.5 billion, with the total budgetary deficit standing at US$437 billion—most of which was being financed by the surplus economies of Europe and Japan.[22] Even the aid projects that the coalition partners had initiated, argued Indian diplomats, were like 'Band-Aid' focused on short-term curative aspects rather than long-term capacity development.[23] It was a horrifying economic scenario that only became worse during the 'great recession' of 2007–09.[24] From the very beginning of the Afghan war, the US had advocated a 'light footprint' model instead of a 'Marshall Plan' for Afghanistan. Moreover, according to Indian policymakers, there was a false impression in the US that the Taliban had been defeated.[25] Formal US military operations against the Taliban had ceased in March 2002, and only 18,000 American and 4,500 ISAF soldiers were stationed in the provincial reconstruction teams (PRTs) in 2003. Indian concerns (like those of many other countries) were highly accurate.

Mukhopadhaya, who was in Kabul as a liaison officer at the time and participated in many closed-door meetings with top Indian and US officials, argued that India's 'greater interest [was] Afghanistan rather than Iraq, so therefore our [Indian] focus should be on Afghanistan. Not only should we not get engaged in Iraq, we should work in order to try and prevent the Americans being distracted from Afghanistan to Iraq'.[26] Top Indian military generals as well as Narayanan were of a similar view.[27] They argued that Washington's focus on Baghdad would make it impervious to Kabul, allowing Islamabad to make inroads by supporting the Taliban's revival. There was considerable skepticism